

THE STYLING LESSON

Meaning, not less

The single most common way to get Japandi wrong is to treat it as minimalism with warmer wood — to strip a room until it is empty and call the emptiness calm. It isn't. An under-furnished room is as wrong as an over-furnished one; it just fails in the other direction, reading as cold, transitional, unloved.

Kanso is the corrective. The question is never "how little can I live with" but "what here actually means something" — and the answer usually keeps more than minimalism would allow: the inherited bowl, the worn chair, the books you return to. Japandi is rich in texture and memory even as it is spare in count. The test is not whether a room is empty. It is whether everything in it is there on purpose.

"Minimalism asks how little. Kanso asks what matters — and keeps it."

